4

Full Steam Ahead

As the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company went ahead full steam, V.O. Chidambaram Pillai was busier than ever, travelling continually on direct company work and to address political gatherings to canvass for shares. '[H]e often had work elsewhere, for instance, at Colombo and Bombay,' recalled a prosecution witness in the sedition case against him; when in Tuticorin, he attended office on the Beach Road, maintaining a daily schedule of 8–12 a.m. and 2–6 p.m.[1]

VOC as assistant secretary, acted as the person managing all company affairs because the company did not have a secretary. The reply of S.K. Marakayar—a local merchant who shipped cattle extensively and whose name was circulated as an early director of SSNCo—to Joint Magistrate Ashe's pointed question, 'Do you know what office Chidambaram Pillai holds in the Company?' in an open court is revealing: 'I don't know, but I know he was managing the affairs of the Company.'[2] VOC's formal designation hardly mattered: he ran the show for all practical purposes and everyone connected with the company, not to speak of the public, saw him as the head of the company.

In the last chapter, we saw how VOC promoted and registered the company. Apart from roping in local merchants, he inducted C. Vijayaraghavachari as legal adviser, and planned the drafting of statutory documents. Before we turn to how he embarked on the purchase of steamers, let us see how he hired various hands for the administration. In making these appointments VOC exercised a free hand.

VOC inspired and identified several young people committed to the Swadeshi cause. Many of them actively participated in both political work and the shipping business. He commanded such respect and admiration that many of them demonstrated a lifelong personal loyalty to him.